

Argument Lab

IDENTIFYING AND CLARIFYING PROPOSITIONS

Part 1: Identify Quality and Quantity

For each proposition, state whether it is affirmative or negative, and whether it is universal or particular. Then write it in standard form (A, E, I, or O).

1. Every citizen has the right to vote.
2. No one under eighteen may purchase alcohol.
3. Some metals conduct electricity.
4. Not every student completed the assignment.
5. All triangles have three sides.
6. Some birds cannot fly.
7. No even number is odd.
8. Most politicians keep their promises.
9. Some ambitious men are not tyrants.
10. No honorable murder is just.
11. All prophecies are dangerous claims.

Part 2: Determine Distribution

For each proposition, indicate whether the subject term and the predicate term are distributed or undistributed.

1. All mammals are warm-blooded.
2. No reptiles are mammals.
3. Some philosophers are logicians.
4. Some philosophers are not logicians.
5. All squares are rectangles.
6. No prime numbers greater than 2 are even.

Part 3: Translate into Standard Form

Rewrite each of the following statements as one of the four standard forms (All S are P, No S are P, Some S are P, Some S are not P). Be prepared to explain your choices.

1. Only registered students may attend the lecture.
2. None but the lonely heart can know my sadness.
3. Every student except freshmen must take the exam.
4. The only people allowed in the room are faculty.
5. Not all that glitters is gold.
6. Nothing is both a square and a circle.
7. Whenever it rains, the ground gets wet.
8. No one succeeds without effort.
9. Caesar alone is dangerous to the republic.
10. Macbeth is not free if the prophecy is certain.

Part 4: Spot the Problem

Each of the following statements is unclear or ambiguous in its quantity or quality. Rewrite each one so that its logical form is explicit and precise.

1. "Politicians lie." (What exactly is being claimed?)
2. "Some people are trustworthy." (Does this mean at least one, or does it suggest not all?)
3. "Students are not prepared for college." (Is this a claim about all students or some?)
4. "No one should be allowed to criticize the government." (Is this universal or particular in scope?)
5. "Caesar is ambitious." (Does this mean all of Caesar's actions are ambitious, or some? What exactly is being asserted?)
6. "Macbeth is fated." (What subject and predicate would make this claim precise enough to test?)

Part 5: Window Note Practice

Choose one proposition from Part 3 and create a window note that shows:

- The original wording
- The standard logical form
- The subject and predicate clearly labeled
- Whether the statement is universal or particular, affirmative or negative

At the bottom, write a short portfolio paragraph explaining why making the quantity and quality explicit changes how the claim could be supported or challenged. If you use *Macbeth* or *Julius Caesar*, explain how the clearer proposition changes the literary argument.